

Editorial

Watch your Words on the Web

B E CAREFUL OF what you post online. The next time you bitch about someone on the Net or criticise your boss or principal or the President—watch it! Depending on what you post, you could lose out on that coveted job you're applying for, or lose the one you have. You could even land up in jail. Don't believe me? Read on:

Vikram Buddhi, an Indian grad student at Purdue University, was recently arrested and charged with threatening to kill George W Bush. Allegedly Buddhi, in various messages posted on a bulletin board, urged the site's readers to bomb the United States and rape American women. In some other messages he posted, he called for the killing of all Republicans. A concerned US citizen contacted the Secret Service office in Dallas to report Buddhi's ramblings on the Net. As of now, Buddhi and his lawyers are fighting for justice, thumping the First Amendment, which by American law assures freedom of speech.

Let's assume Buddhi did write what is alleged, which, of course, is highly objectionable. But aren't we usually frivolous when chatting on the Net? I mean, chat rooms and bulletin boards are the kind of places where you vent your emotions—however negative those may be, unwind after a hard day at work, and speak your mind—knowing (or believing) you won't be taken seriously. But this piece of news threatens to change that. You've now got to be careful about what you post online.

This brings me to what I'm trying to say here: Big Brother. OK, the phrase is clichéd and done to a dodo's death, but there are three things I'm talking about: freedom of speech, the way information travels on the Web, and the monitoring of your online actions. First, what has happened to the First Amendment? I thought you could say—at least in the US—what you wanted to. How can you arrest someone who hasn't *done anything*? Obviously, it's American post-9/11 paranoia that's at work here, which is evident from American blogs that are expressing satisfaction that something has been nipped in the bud. Second, remember that what you write online can conceivably be linked to by someone else and on and on—next thing you know, someone incriminates you out of context for something you don't even remember you posted. And third, you're being monitored. If not by the Secret Service, by job recruiters, for example.

What is increasingly becoming a trend these days amongst recruiters or HR officials is to dig deeper on



Deepak Ajwani Associate Editor

**“Ramblings in chat rooms
and on bulletin boards can get you
behind bars!”**

a potential candidate, with his or her résumé as a starting point. You may have been a college topper and rattled off big-ticket achievements during your previous job stints, but if your name pulls up incriminating stuff on a Google search, you're in for trouble. Be smart enough to not use your real name and other details that can identify you.

Companies can do a random background check on you. Be doubly sure that the information on your résumé matches your Web presence. If you blog, be careful of how much you share about your personal life. They're watching you. And god help you if you start slandering even a company you worked for three years ago.

People are today expressing themselves online more prolifically, and in more ways than before—it's a rising trend, as you know. But—need we say it again?—be careful of what you post online.

editor@thinkdigit.com